

Haiku Japanese Polish (Kawagita method)

This skill captures how 川北泰徳 (Yoshinori Kawagita, as he romanises it) edits Rob's haiku — first the sequence *The Ocean Beneath the Ice* (15 haiku), then a set of five single haiku (July 2026), then the sequence お風呂が待っている (10 haiku, Sept 2026). His edits are consistent enough to be a method. Apply it to any new haiku Rob brings.

His own definition of 添削: 言葉を換えたり、書き加えたり、削ったりして俳句の表現を変えて、よりよい俳句にすること — swap words, add, cut, to make a better haiku. All three moves are fair game.

The mora-counting rules and both full sets of Kawagita-san's before/after examples are appended below.

Core principles (in priority order)

1. **5-7-5 is non-negotiable — but a labelled 字余り opening is acceptable.** Every rewrite he produced is 5-7-5 (五・七・五の定型のリズムに整えましょう). Fix the count first. A 6-8-5 draft gets fully rebuilt, not trimmed. The one exception: he will allow a 7-syllable *opening* line if he flags it explicitly — ※ 上5・字余り 7音 (an opening line of seven syllables.) — never silently.

1b. **Kigo: at most one, never two.** He translated the Ocean sequence "regardless of whether it includes a season word", so a kigo is not required. But when kigo appear, he insists on exactly one (季語を一つだけにしましょう). Watch for hidden pairs: 咳 and くしゃみ are both winter kigo; 花, 春の風 and 山笑う are all spring. Name the season of each kigo you keep. When a draft is short, adding a kigo is his preferred way to fill the missing 5 (梅雨晴れ間).

2. **Count mora, not syllables.** ん, っ, and — each count as one. Small やゆよ do not. ガソリンスタンド = 8, ガススタンド = 6. Write the count under every segment, every time, so errors are visible. See [references/mora_counting.md](#).

3. **Compact native / Sino-Japanese words beat katakana loanwords.** ガソリンスタンドに (9) → ガススタンドに (7) → 給油所に (5). The kango version is both shorter and more haiku-like. Look for the 漢語 equivalent of any loanword.

4. **Use literary (文語) verb and adjective forms.** This is the single biggest "sounds like a real haiku" lever. Kawagita's swaps:

- 凍りし → 凍てて | 落ちる → 落つ | 越えゆく → 越ゆる
- 押さえられない → 押さえきれざる | 輝く → 輝けり
- 見る → 眺む / 仰ぐ | ひらく → ひらけゆく / ひらきけり
- 開き始める → 開き初む (そむ) | 青い → 青き
- 知らなかった → 知らざりき (didn't know / knew it not) | 抱いていた...か → 抱きしや...いな彼女 (classical "A or, nay, B" construction)
- 静かな → 淡き (faint, more evocative than "quiet") | 光は届く → 光射す (light shines forth, one concrete verb beats a generic one) | 心 → 心奥 (bottom of the heart, when the plain word feels flat)

Use them naturally; don't stack archaic forms until it reads as pastiche.

5. **End with a cut (切れ) where possible.** Favourite closers from the edits: 〜けり (ひらきけり, 輝けり), 〜かな (くしゃみかな), 〜む (眺む, 初む), 〜つ (落つ), and the opening や (白面や, 侘び文や). けり adds a sense of realisation; や opens with an exclamation.

6. **Turn explanation into image; turn abstraction into first-person feeling.** "The mind tries to hold the heart down" → not 頭で押さえ (head/brain, clinical) but 心では押さえきれざるわが想い — "my feelings, which my heart cannot hold down." Drop the mechanism, keep the feeling. Likewise 言葉になる前 (before becoming words — prose) → 言葉とならず (never becoming words — poetry).
7. **Reach for poetic synonyms.** 言葉 → 言の葉 (ことのは), 海 → 海原 (うなばら), 空 → 大空, 句 → 詩の言の葉. These lift register and often fix the count at the same time.
8. **Reorder freely.** Japanese lets you move the nature image to the front: 心より湧き 山越ゆる 愛の水 → 愛の水 心より湧き 山を越え. Offer both; reordering is often how a 7-5-5 becomes a clean 5-7-5.
9. **Enjambment (句跨がり) is allowed but must be labelled.** If the natural phrase boundaries land on 7-5-5, keep it as a variant, mark it ※ 句跨がり (enjambéd line), and also give a re-cut 5-7-5 version (心より湧き / 山越ゆる → 心より / 湧き山越ゆる).
10. **Don't over-edit.** When the draft already works, say so: (It's fine as it is.) and stop. Four of fifteen were left untouched. Restraint is part of the method.
11. **Offer 2-3 alternatives, not one answer.** Each with a one-line gloss when the nuance differs (眺む = gaze at; 仰ぐ = look up at). Rob chooses.
12. **Complete fragments with a thing, not a thought.** A 5-7 draft gets its final 5 from a concrete object or a kigo: 旅立つ荷, 梅雨晴れ間, 旅をして. Never pad with an abstract noun.
13. **Flag private references.** 杖の花 meant 御杖村 to Rob; to a Japanese reader it meant nothing (意味がよくわかりません). If an image only works with biographical context, say so and offer a replacement that stands alone. Rob can decide to keep the private version for himself.
14. **Check particles.** 荷を添う → 荷に添いて. A wrong particle marks a poem as non-native faster than anything else.
15. **Vary the angle across alternatives.** For the cat/koto haiku he gave three rewrites with three different stances: detached scene ending in かな, onomatopoeia (くしゅんと), and first-person domestic humour (夫のしわぶき気にせずに). Alternatives should differ in viewpoint or tone, not just word choice.
16. **Back-translate when meaning shifted.** If the polished Japanese says something the English didn't (花園に → 心の花園 "garden of my heart"), add one English line under it so Rob sees what changed.
17. **Cut source content that won't fit the meter — say so explicitly.** If an English phrase can't be fit into 5-7-5 without wrecking it, drop it rather than force it, and note it: ※ I omitted the phrase "the stem rising straight" / ※ I omitted 'slowly' to fit the syllable limit. Meter wins over completeness; the omission is disclosed, not hidden.
18. **It's fine to leave the choice open.** Several verses end with 2-3 fully-formed candidates and no final pick — he doesn't always converge on one "best" version. Presenting live alternatives for Rob to choose from is itself a valid finished state, not a sign the edit is incomplete.

Workflow

1. Read the source haiku (English/Dutch/Japanese). Identify the core image, the turn/cut, and any implied season.
2. Draft a literal Japanese version first — this is the "before" line, useful for showing the path.
3. Count every segment. Mark counts under each block: 5 7 5.
4. Check kigo count (1b), particles (14), and private references (13).
5. Apply principles 3–8 to reach 5-7-5 and literary register. Produce 2-3 candidates with different angles

(15).

6. Label enjambed variants; gloss verb choices; back-translate any meaning shift.

7. If the draft already satisfies everything, write (It's fine as it is.) and offer at most one optional alternative.

8. Add furigana to every kanji using Rob's format: 漢字《よみ》 (e.g. 白面《はくめん》や). Readings go after the kanji compound, not per character.

Output format

ALWAYS use this layout (it mirrors the Kawagita manuscript):

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## N. [Source haiku in English/Dutch]

[literal Japanese draft with furigana]

↓

[candidate 1 with furigana]    ※ note if any
5       7       5

[candidate 2 with furigana]    ※ 句跨がり (enjambement) / gloss
5       7       5

[optional back-translation in English]
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Use full-width spaces () between the three segments. Put (It's fine as it is.) at the end of the draft line when no change is needed.

Things to watch

- in katakana counts; many English-derived words are longer in mora than they look.
- 「家」 added to a surname (松岡家) makes it unambiguous that a family is meant and adds a mora.
- Kawagita keeps particles minimal in the 5s: 山眺む not 山を眺む. Drop を/は when the count demands it and the meaning survives.
- Keep Rob's multilingual intent: if the haiku exists in English and Dutch too, polish only the Japanese here; flag if the Japanese now diverges from the other two.
- For a sequence, keep recurring images consistent across poems (愛の水 / 愛の波 / 愛の海原 all echo each other on purpose).

Mora counting for haiku (音数)

Haiku count **mora** (拍), not syllables.

Counts as 1	Does NOT count
every kana (あ, か, ガ ...)	small や ゆ よ (きょ = 1)

Counts as 1	Does NOT count
ん	—
っ (sokuon)	—
— (long vowel mark)	—
each kana of a long vowel written out (おお, こう = 2)	—

Worked counts

Word	Kana	Mora
ガソリンスタンド	がそりんすたんど	8
ガススタンド	がすすたんど	6
給油所に	きゅうゆしょに	5 (きゅ・う・ゆ・しょ・に)
白面や	はくめんや	5
海原	うなばら	4
言の葉は	ことのはは	5
松岡家	まつおかけ	5
大空へ	おおぞらへ	5
輝けり	かがやけり	5
押さえきれざる	おさえきれざる	7

Tip: convert to hiragana, strip small やゆよ, then count characters.

Common traps

- Katakana loanwords almost always run long (コンピュータ = 6, スマートフォン = 7).
- 長音 in kanji readings: 東京 = とうきょう = 4, not 2.
- Classical endings change counts: 見る (2) → 眺む (3) → 仰ぐ (3); 輝く (4) → 輝けり (5); 落ちる (3) → 落つ (2).
- The suffix ちゃん (-chan, e.g. さくらちゃん, おばあちゃん) is pronounced/counted as **one mora**, not two — an explicit exception noted by Kawagita-san (source: 夏水仙の彼方 corrections, poems 1 and 2).
- Some vowel-glide compounds also contract to **one mora** for scansion, e.g. ちか in 名もなき力に (力 = ちから counted short) and ひら in 心の窓の向こうにて — Kawagita flags these inline: ※ pronounce 'chika'/'hira' as single syllable. Treat this as a pattern (not just these two words): when a count looks one-over, check whether he's silently relying on a contraction and ask if uncertain rather than assume it doesn't apply (source: お風呂が待っている corrections, poems 8-9).